

Start From This Line

DIFFICULT PRACTICE



Name: _____

Date set: _____

Due: _____

YOUR OPENING LINE — USE IT EXACTLY, WORD FOR WORD, AS THE FIRST LINE OF YOUR STORY

“By the time anyone thought to ask, it was already too late to matter.”

Unlike “continue the story,” you are building everything after this line yourself — including who “anyone” is, what they should have asked, and why it’s too late. This line can open a story in almost any genre. Choose one direction and commit to it fully rather than trying to keep several possibilities open.

YOUR WRITING

CHECKLIST – GO OVER IT AGAIN

1. Check your opening line was copied **exactly**, word for word, with correct punctuation.
2. By the end, a reader can look back and see exactly what "it" and "too late" referred to – without you explaining the line directly early on.
3. Read the whole piece back – does the ending genuinely justify the ominous opening, or does the story undersell it?
4. Tense and person stay consistent (or any deliberate shift is clearly signalled).
5. At least 2 pieces of figurative language that fit your chosen tone, and varied sentence openings throughout.
6. No unearned twist – a strong ending should feel inevitable once you know it, not random.